

incongruous Baroque, 17th-century lantern. Similarly, black-and-white horizontal marble stripes run around the entire building. They are conspicuously present on the six-story, square bell tower, next to the south transept. This banding is continued throughout the vividly rich interior, which is also notable for its intricate marble floor.

Sainte-Chapelle

Location Paris, France

Sainte-Chapelle, completed in 1248, is the purest expression of the Gothic style in France. In essence, the chapel is no more than a delicately ribbed framework supported by flying buttresses, and its walls are its stunning stained-glass windows. The result is a uniform, vertiginous space. It was built as a chapel but has become an oversized reliquary, housing some of the most venerated relics in Christendom: a fragment of the true cross and the crown of thorns, acquired by the pious Louis IX. Where the interior is not gilded, it is painted. The deep-blue vaulted ceiling is covered with gold *fleur-de-lys*, and a needlelike *flèche* (spire) soars from the pitch of the roof. The church was heavily damaged during the French Revolution but restored in the mid-19th century.

San Pablo

Location Valladolid, Spain

The church of San Pablo in Valladolid was built between 1445 and 1468, although its most notable feature, the facade, was completed in 1550. It is an extreme example of what has come to be known as Isabeline architecture, named after Isabella I who, with her husband Ferdinand II, expelled the last of the Moors



from Spain in 1492. If in style it sits somewhere between the last vestiges of the Gothic and the Classicism of the early Renaissance—laced with Flemish and Moorish influences—its most obvious characteristic is its extreme elaboration of detail. Two rough-hewn square towers frame San Pablo's pedimented facade, which bursts with sculptured decorative features, including figures, coats of arms, tracery, and finials.

Malbork Castle

Location Malbork, Poland

Malbork Castle on the Nogat River, built from the late 13th century onward, was the headquarters of the Teutonic Knights. This was a crusading

▲ BRICK-BUILT GOTHIC STRUCTURE AT MALBORK CASTLE

order that, from 1233, had been given papal permission to convert Europe's Baltic states, chiefly Prussia, to Christianity. By 1309, when the Teutonic Grand Master established himself at Malbork, the Teutonic Knights controlled a substantial Christian Baltic state. In due course, the castle—built throughout in red brick—would become the world's largest, sprawling over 3.4 million square ft (320,000 square m). In addition to immensely powerful defensive walls and towers, the castle contains a series of sumptuous Gothic residences—notably the Palace of the Grand Master, a lavish, four-story brick-built structure completed in 1399.

Albi Cathedral

Location Albi, France

Albi Cathedral, begun in 1282, seems more like a fortress than a place of worship. This is no accident. It was built following the 12th-century Cathar heresy—a major challenge to the Roman Catholic Church—in Languedoc, southwest France. The brick-built cathedral was constructed as an absolute reminder of the reach of the Church, albeit filtered through local styles. In place of the soaring cathedrals of northern France, with flying buttresses, huge windows, and upward-reaching spires, Albi Cathedral has buttresses that merely bulge from the walls; its windows are little more than vertical slits; and the thick-set tower at the west end is more Romanesque than Gothic.